

Urban Co-Living Platform

Affordable Housing Product Strategy for Young Professionals

Google PM Certificate Capstone · Product Management · 8 Weeks

Role	Product Manager (Capstone)
Programme	Google Project Management Certificate
Duration	8 weeks
Methodology	Agile / Design Thinking
Research	15 user interviews
Key Finding	73% willingness to adopt with trust and verification features

15 User Interviews	2 Personas Created	73% Willingness to Adopt	3 Success Metrics
--------------------------	--------------------------	--------------------------------	-------------------------

01 Project Overview

This capstone project from the Google Project Management Certificate tasked me with designing a product from the ground up using the full PM toolkit: problem framing, user research, persona development, feature prioritisation, roadmap creation, and success metrics definition.

I chose to tackle affordable co-living for young professionals in urban centres: a problem shaped by rising rents, limited housing supply, and trust and safety challenges that make shared living unappealing even when financially necessary. The goal was to design a platform that made co-living genuinely accessible, transparent, and safe.

The project ran across 8 weeks following Agile sprint cycles, and culminated in a validated product strategy supported by primary user research with 15 participants.

02 The Problem

Research surfaced four consistent friction points that existing co-living options fail to address.

- **Trust and safety:** Moving in with strangers without reliable verification is a barrier many potential users cannot get past, particularly women living alone

- **Transparency:** Hidden costs and ambiguous house rules create post-move-in disputes that erode platform trust
- **Compatibility matching:** Random roommate pairing leads to lifestyle mismatches, producing conflict and high turnover
- **Community:** Purely transactional arrangements do not address the social isolation young professionals in new cities experience

03 User Research

I conducted 15 in-depth interviews with young professionals aged 22 to 34, targeting people currently renting alone, in shared housing, or actively searching for affordable options. Interviews averaged 45 minutes and followed a semi-structured format.

Key Findings

- 87% cited safety and trust as their primary barrier to co-living, ahead of cost and availability
- 73% said they would adopt a co-living platform with verified profiles, transparent pricing, and compatibility matching
- 68% had previously tried shared housing that ended due to lifestyle incompatibility rather than financial reasons
- 61% valued community features, but only as a secondary consideration after safety and transparency
- Women participants (9 of 15) placed significantly higher emphasis on safety verification

04 User Personas

Research data consolidated into two primary personas representing distinct motivational profiles.

Amara, 26 — The Safety-First Mover

Recently relocated to a new city for work. Renting alone is financially unsustainable but previous bad experiences with unverified flatmates have made her reluctant to try co-living again. Core need: I need to know who I am living with before I say yes to anything.

David, 29 — The Community Builder

Has co-lived before and values the social aspect, but has had two bad experiences with incompatible roommates. Wants a platform that does the compatibility work upfront. Core need: The idea is right, the matching is just always wrong.

05 Product Strategy

Research findings shaped a strategy organised around three core principles: verify first, match meaningfully, and price transparently. Safety and verification features were classified as non-negotiable foundations regardless of build cost.

Priority Features (MVP)

- **Verified identity and background checks:** Mandatory for all users before any listing or enquiry
- **Lifestyle compatibility questionnaire:** Structured pre-match survey covering sleep, cleanliness, social preferences, work patterns, and guest policies
- **Transparent pricing breakdown:** All-inclusive cost display from first interaction, with all fees itemised before commitment
- **Secure in-platform messaging:** All pre-move communication on-platform; no personal contact details exchanged until both parties confirm interest

Phase 2 Features (Post-MVP)

- Community events calendar and shared interest groups per property
- In-app maintenance request and issue tracking
- Review system for both hosts and co-livers post-stay
- Flexible short-term lease options (3 to 6 months)

06 Success Metrics

Three outcome-focused metrics were defined to measure whether the product was solving the core research problems, not generating vanity engagement.

Metric	Definition	Target (6 months)
Match Retention Rate	Percentage of arrangements still active at 3 months; indicates compatibility matching is working	70% of matches still active at 3 months
Safety Satisfaction Score	Post-move-in survey score specifically on safety and trust experience	4.2 out of 5.0 average
Pricing Disputes	Number of post-move-in disputes citing unexpected costs; measures transparency	Below 5% of completed matches

07 PM Skills Demonstrated

PM Competency	How It Showed Up
User Research	15 semi-structured interviews with a defined participant profile; findings systematically coded and quantified
Persona Development	Two data-driven personas built from research patterns; each with a distinct motivational profile
Problem Framing	Research reframed the problem from affordable housing to trusted co-living, shifting the entire product strategy

Feature Prioritisation	Value vs. effort matrix used to separate MVP from Phase 2; safety features protected as non-negotiable
Metrics Definition	Three outcome-focused success metrics tied directly to research problems, not vanity metrics
Agile Methodology	8-week project structured as sprint cycles with defined deliverables and retrospective review between phases
Product Roadmapping	MVP vs. Phase 2 roadmap with sequencing rationale grounded in user research data

08 Reflections and Learnings

Going into the research phase, I expected affordability to dominate the findings. It came third. Safety and trust were the real barriers, and most participants had mentally accepted the cost of co-living long before they encountered the platform trust problem. That single finding reversed the priority order for nearly every feature decision.

The discipline of defining success metrics before building the roadmap was the most practically useful part of the process. It forced clarity on what working actually meant for this product, and surfaced the fact that traditional engagement metrics would tell you almost nothing about whether the core promise was being kept.

If this were going to a real product team, the next step would be a prototype usability test focused specifically on the verification and matching flows, where the gap between what users say they want and what they will actually complete in practice is likely to be widest.

Moyinoluwa Kemi Idowu · kiishiidowu@gmail.com · [Open to Remote Roles](#)